
research article

The policy engagement of social workers: a research overview

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Policy engagement by social workers that seeks to impact public policies that advance social justice and human rights has, and continues to be, a core component of the social work profession. This has also led to a growing volume of research focusing upon the routes that social workers can take to be part of the policy formulation process. The aim of this article is to provide a research overview of five policy routes, which include two civic routes, specifically voluntary political participation and holding elected office, and three professional routes, specifically policy practice, academic policy engagement and policy participation through professional organisations. The overview expands our knowledge on contemporary research trends regarding the level of engagement in each route, the form that this takes and the factors that explain it. The factors that have been identified in the research literature as impacting social workers' policy engagement will draw upon the policy engagement conceptual framework. The methodologies employed in the studies are discussed. Finally, the article concludes by identifying under-researched facets of social workers' policy engagement and suggesting a research agenda for the field.

Key words social workers • policy • research • political involvement • advocacy

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Introduction

From the very early days of the social work profession, the idea that social workers (SWs) should impact public policies has been embedded in its discourse. In his 1920 book *The Social Worker*, Clement Attlee, then a lecturer on social work and later the British Prime Minister (Dickens, 2018), made this clear when he noted that 'almost every social worker is almost certain to be an agitator' (Attlee, 1920: 237). Despite the unusual terminology, Attlee immediately clarified that what he calls 'agitation' is, in fact, a social worker engaging in policy: '[This] particular function being to concentrate attention on particular aspects of the social problem, to spread information or at least a desire for information, and to generate the

power necessary to make the slow moving machinery of society work' (Attlee, 1920: 238). The literature on SWs' policy engagement in the years since has tended to focus on three distinct, though at times overlapping, discourses: the normative, the educational (both descriptive and evaluative) and engagement research. Normative debates on the policy role of SWs have taken place for nearly as long as the profession has existed, often reflecting more general trends within social work concerning the individual–societal or the micro–macro divides. While there was a clear desire during some periods to prefer individual-level interventions and to curtail involvement in policy and politics (Solender, 1958), in recent decades, overt opposition to a policy role has generally receded. This has been replaced by a more determined effort on the part of social work professional organisations (SWPOs), scholars and practitioners to encourage SWs to actively affect policy. By underscoring the value base of this engagement and its importance for meeting social work goals and service users' needs, and by depicting the activities through which this can be undertaken, policy engagement is construed as a crucial component of the social work profession around the world (Hoefer, 2019; Pawar, 2019; Saxena and Chandrapal, 2022).

Concurrently a burgeoning number of publications have described, and sometimes evaluated, educational efforts to enable social work students to become policy actors (Weiss-Gal, 2016). A major driving factor behind the growth in work on the contribution of educational efforts to SWs' policy engagement were efforts by US social work scholars from the mid-1980s onwards to include policy practice (PP) as one of the ten core competencies required by the Council on Social Work Education for the accreditation of social work training in that country (Byers, 2014). Educators in the US and elsewhere sought to equip social work students with the value base, attitudes, skills and sense of internal and external political efficacy needed to become policy actors (Lane et al, 2018; Schwartz-Tayri et al, 2020; Meehan, 2021). The subsequent body of research on policy engagement training explored the efficacy of these efforts and indicated that the use of diverse didactic methods in a professional socialisation process that underscores the policy role of social workers can contribute to SWs' readiness to engage in policy after graduation and their entry into the field (Weiss-Gal, 2016; Pawar and Nixon, 2021).

A third discourse in the policy engagement literature, and the subject of this article, consists of research on SWs' policy engagement. Over the years, social work scholars have sought to better understand the diverse ways in which SWs have engaged in, what Attlee called, 'agitation' to promote better and more just social policies and to fulfil their core mission of affecting the environment within which service users exist. With growing theoretical and methodological sophistication and innovativeness, scholars from across the globe have created a solid research infrastructure on this subject and, no less important, forged the basis of knowledge that SWs and social work students can draw upon to play a role in social policy formulation processes.

This article charts the contours of the research on SWs' policy engagement by relating to five different routes through which SWs impact policy. It is an integrative literature review that endeavours to provide a comprehensive overview of major trends in the field. We begin with a brief summary of developments in this body of research and then discuss key issues that research has sought to address with regard to each of the routes. We conclude with a research agenda.

A research overview

Pioneering empirical attempts to study aspects of SWs' engagement in policy processes began in the 1960s (Heffernan, 1964). Yet, it was only in the 1980s that more concerted and systematic research efforts began to emerge in the US (Epstein, 1981; Wolk, 1981). Since then, research on the policy engagement of SWs has grown in volume and sophistication, and moved beyond its initial North American focus. Scholars from countries like Australia, Belgium, Canada, China, Egypt, Germany, Israel, Italy, South Africa and Switzerland have sought to better understand the engagement of SWs in policy processes and how political, social and professional contexts modify this engagement (Klammer et al, 2020; Guidi, 2020; Lombard and Viviers, 2020; Nouman et al, 2020; Amann and Kindler, 2022; Cai et al, 2022).

This body of research enables us to identify five policy routes through which SWs have endeavoured to influence policy design (Weiss-Gal, 2017a).¹ In all of these routes, SWs seek to impact policies at the local, regional, national or federal levels, whether through the formulation of new policies, by defending existing policies and suggesting changes in them, or by resisting policy proposals detrimental to service users.

Two of these routes – voluntary political participation (VPP) (Ritter, 2008) and holding elected office (Amann and Kindler, 2022) – occur in the civic sphere, with SWs acting as citizens in the political process. SWs engage in these routes as private citizens and not in their formal capacity as professional SWs, as the routes exist beyond the boundaries of the SWs' employment setting. VPP refers to a wide range of activities, ranging from voting and campaigning, to protest activities. SWs engage in these as part of their civic participation in a democratic political process, with the ultimate goal of impacting policy change. Holding elected office, whether at the local, county, state or federal level, is a second civic route. It enables SWs to become formal policy actors and offers them the capacity to influence the policy formulation process from within.

The three professional routes are those in which SWs engage in affecting policy design as professionals: PP; policy involvement by SWPOs; and academic policy involvement. PP (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2023) refers to one-off or ongoing intentional on-the-job professional activities undertaken by SWs, either on their own initiative or on that of others, as an integral part of their professional work. In contrast to the two previous routes, SWs engaging in PP do so in their work setting. That is to say, they do not play a voluntary political role, but undertake policy-related activities as professional employees.

SWs are also involved in policy through SWPOs, which can serve as recruitment networks or as proxies (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2023). As recruitment networks, they offer space for SWs' collective policy engagement. When acting as proxies, SWPOs relieve rank-and-file members of the need to be involved directly in the policy process. Thus, SWs engage in policy processes indirectly through the policy engagement of the SWPOs that represent them. This is a crucial option for SWs whose place of employment restricts their policy-change activities.

Finally, academic policy involvement refers to the involvement of social work faculty and students in policy-related activities. This type of policy engagement can take place through university–community partnerships, teaching and the individual engagement of social work scholars (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2017). Here, we will relate to the involvement of social work scholars in the policy processes as individuals.

Research on the policy routes has generally focused on three facets of SWs' policy engagement (Weiss-Gal, 2017b). The first is an ongoing empirical attempt to gauge the degree to which SWs engage in each of the routes. Efforts to study which strategies and activities have been adopted in each of them is a second facet, and research that has sought to better understand the factors that impact SWs' engagement in each of the policy routes is a third. The following sections of the article will discuss each of these facets.

Research on the policy engagement of SWs in each of these routes has employed diverse research designs and methodologies. Among these are: quantitative surveys, typically using convenience samples of SWs (Mattocks, 2018); historical and policy analyses (Peffer Talbot and McMillin, 2014); content analyses (Weiss-Gal and Gal, 2014); and a combination of content analysis and qualitative approaches, drawing upon focus groups (Mendes et al, 2015) or interviews (Guidi, 2020). A number of issues emerge regarding methodology. One is common to much of the research on social work practice, though is equally relevant to the study of policy engagement, and concerns data sources. The tendency of most of this research is to draw upon the retrospective self-report of SWs. This inevitably gives rise to questions concerning social desirability and recall. Some policy engagement studies have tackled this issue by employing content analyses of comments and testimonies (McCullagh, 1987) or of the minutes of parliamentary committees (Weiss-Gal and Gal, 2014). Another major issue linked specifically to studies on the extent of SWs' policy engagement relates to the difficulty in interpreting the results and determining what is considered a low, moderate or high level of engagement, especially when only a limited number of studies compare SWs with other professional groups. In addition, the studies have employed different definitions and measurements of policy engagement and frequently do not differentiate between SWs' activities as citizens outside their work setting and their PP activities as professionals. Finally, most quantitative studies use convenience samples, many with relatively small sample sizes.

Researching the extent

Obviously, a vital initial question pertaining to SWs' policy engagement is the degree to which they are actually involved in policy-change activities. While there is unequivocal evidence that SWs do indeed engage in each of the various policy routes (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2023), the extent of their involvement varies much across the different routes, by its form within the routes, between countries and over time.

Due to its voluntary and often less-demanding nature, VPP is arguably the most common policy route among SWs, though adoption of this policy route diverges across countries. Scholars in the US found that half or more of their samples were actively or very actively involved in VPP (Ritter, 2007; Harris Rome and Hoechstetter, 2010), while studies in other countries indicated that the extent of this was low (Gray and Van Rooyen, 2000) or moderate (Dudziak and Coates, 2004). Cross-national comparisons reveal that SWs in New Zealand tend to be more politically active than their counterparts in Australia, South Africa (Gray et al, 2002) and Hong Kong (Chui and Gray, 2004), and US SWs were found to be more politically active than their Swiss counterparts (Ostrander et al, 2021). Studies on voting, the most common form of VPP, indicate that the level among SWs was higher than that of the general

public in the US (Felderhoff et al, 2016), Canada (Douglas, 2008), New Zealand, South Africa (Gray et al, 2002) and Hong Kong (Chui and Gray, 2004).

Of late, there is growing evidence from a number of countries of SWs' readiness to run for, or hold, elected political offices, though there are, as yet, few data on the extent of this. Nevertheless, we do know that SWs have opted for this route in Canada (McLaughlin et al, 2019), Germany (Leitner and Stolz, 2022), Israel (Binder and Weiss-Gal, 2022), Switzerland (Amann and Kindler, 2022), the UK (Gwilym, 2017) and the US (Lane and Humphreys, 2011; Pence and Kaiser, 2022).

Most of the knowledge on the level of SWs' on-the-job PP emerges from studies that examine a wide range of social work activities (of which PP is one) or that study diverse forms of social advocacy (which include civic routes alongside PP). Studies focusing specifically on PP are rare but have been undertaken in the US, Canada and Israel (Weiss-Gal, 2017b). The studies indicate that the level of this type of practice is low, particularly among direct practitioners, though higher among community SWs (Weiss-Gal et al, 2020). With this, in recent years, there has been growing evidence of the PP of SWs employed by local government who act as policy entrepreneurs (Lavee and Cohen, 2019; Zhang et al, 2021). These SWs do not focus on improving the implementation of existing policies or limit themselves to specific ad hoc policy activities. Rather, they are energetic actors engaged in long-term, ongoing and diverse policy activities, working with others in and around policymaking venues, and directing efforts and resources to engage in policy change. A study undertaken in Israel showed how these efforts led to the adoption of local policy changes: integrating social considerations into urban planning; incorporating employment policies into local social services; and providing social services for migrant workers despite the lack of central government legitimization or support (Aviv et al, 2021).

SWPOs serve as proxies for their members or recruit them to impact social policies that relate to service users and not just promote professional interests (Sicora and Citroni, 2021). Research shows that this is the case for the National Association of Social Workers (NASW) in the US (Colby and Buffum, 1998; Beimers, 2015), the British Association of Social Workers (Payne, 2002), the Italian Consiglio Nazionale Ordine Assistenti Sociali (CNOAS), the Spanish Consejo General del Trabajo Social (CGTS) (Guidi, 2020) and the Australian Association of Social Workers (Mendes et al, 2015). This is even more so for grass-roots radical organisations, such as SWAN (Moth and Lavalette, 2020). Data on the degree to which SWs participate in efforts to further these policies are scarce, though there is evidence that the capacity of SWPOs to recruit SWs to engage in policy and the extent to which the organisations attempt to affect social policies differ across nations (Guidi, 2020).

Finally, although social work scholars play policy roles as individuals, the extent of their involvement is limited. A cross-national comparative study undertaken among 1,551 social work academics from 12 countries and a subsequent Canadian study found that social work academics' policy engagement in all the countries studies ranged from low to moderate (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2017; Tham and Thorén, 2020; Shewell et al, 2021). However, a comparison with faculty in other helping professions (education and healthcare) in Israel showed that the levels of engagement in some of the activities (for example, working directly with policymakers, serving on committees that discussed policy or participating in coalitions and protests) was higher among social work scholars (Weiss-Gal and Gal, 2019).

The form

Research reveals the diverse activities undertaken by SWs seeking to impact policies by engaging in each of the five policy routes. The findings also indicate which activities are more and less prevalent among SWs. As is the case with regard to the extent of engagement, the findings on the forms of engagement are often country and time dependent.

SWs' VPP typically comprises voting, campaigning, non-electoral activities and protest activities. Voting is a common and frequent activity among the samples of SWs in all countries studied (Weiss-Gal, 2017b; Ostrander et al, 2021), while the frequency of campaigning tends to diverge by country and over time. In earlier studies, it appeared that in the US (Reeser and Epstein, 1990; Ritter, 2007) and Canada (Douglas, 2008), SWs frequently contributed to a candidate or political party, and campaigned on behalf of candidates or parties. In other countries, such as Australia, New Zealand, South Africa and Canada, this type of VPP activity was much less common (Hardina, 1995; Gray et al, 2002). A recent comparison of US and Swiss SWs found low levels of engagement in campaigning, such as in volunteering for a political campaign or working for pay for a political campaign, in both groups (Ostrander et al, 2021).

In contrast to campaigning, non-electoral political activities are more common among SWs. SWs in various countries frequently discussed political issues with others (Chui and Gray, 2004; Dudziak and Coates, 2004; Harris Rome and Hoechstetter, 2010; Ostrander et al, 2021), and some contacted policymakers concerning a national or local policy problem (Mary, 2001). SWs in several national cohorts also participated in political meetings and in community or interest groups working on policy problems (Wolk, 1981; Cohen, 1987; Mary, 2001). Much less frequent was presenting oral testimony to legislative committees (Ritter, 2007; Harris Rome and Hoechstetter, 2010).

Of the four types of VPP studied, protest activity was the least common among SWs, though its extent clearly depended on the context. While in the US (Reeser and Epstein, 1990; Harris Rome and Hoechstetter, 2010; Ostrander et al, 2021), Canada (Hardina, 1995) and Hong Kong (Lai, 2004), SWs participated less in protest activities, higher levels of participation in demonstrations emerged in Australia (Frederico and Puckett, 1988) and in Israel (Cohen, 1987). A qualitative study asserted that during economic and social crises in Greece, Spain and Portugal, SWs increased their engagement in protest activities (Ioakimidis et al, 2014). Despite the difficulty in reaching an overall conclusion from these results, they appear to indicate that SWs' VPP is generally characterised by a reluctance to embrace activities that require initiative and the intense investment of resources, and that have a potential for overt conflict.

Studies have shed some light on the strategies adopted by SWs in elected offices. Kindler and Amann (2022) examined the strategies used by 31 Swiss SWs in elected offices for influencing policymaking processes. It emerged that the SWs were involved in bringing social work's professional expertise about social problems into policymaking processes, both by case-study storytelling and by presenting data and figures. The SWs also engaged in networking through their contacts with administrative officials, politicians, representatives of associations and service users. They reported mediating between the interests of these stakeholders, noting that the stronger the existing network, the more successful the mediation attempts.

The studies that focused specifically or exclusively on on-the-job PP showed that SWs engaged in diverse policy activities as part of their job (Douglas, 2008; Weiss-Gal, 2017b; Lavee and Cohen, 2019; Weiss-Gal et al, 2020; Gilboa and Weiss-Gal, 2022). These include: researching and analysing social or policy problems; acquiring political knowledge and sharing it with service users and other stakeholders; working with community groups to influence policy and participating in coalitions; legislative advocacy; testifying in parliamentary committees; and working with government officials. SWs organised meetings with decision makers and between them and people affected by the problem, and used the media to impact policy.

As is the case with VPP, the extent of SWs' engagement in each type of PP activity diverged significantly. This is reflected in a study comparing the PP of 621 Israeli SWs, which showed that although the SWs did inform policymakers about a policy problem or limitation, they integrated into their professional practice primarily indirect and informal forms of policy engagement. More specifically, they engaged more in bringing social problems or policy limitations to colleagues' attention, enhancing service users' awareness of a policy problem or participating in a conference that sought to bring a policy problem to the attention of the public or policymakers. They were less engaged in helping service users organise a campaign against a detrimental policy or participating in protest activities against such policies. In addition, their PP had a much more internal focus: they were more involved in activities related to the policies of their own organisation and much less in policy activities intended to influence local or national policies (Weiss-Gal et al, 2020). Similarly, a qualitative study that drew upon semi-structured interviews with 18 Israeli local government community SWs who engaged in PP depicted how the SWs adopted a 'collaborative institutional PP', which was based primarily on collaborative and consensual strategies (Gilboa and Weiss-Gal, 2022).

Research on the policy engagement of SWPOs sheds some light on the policy areas and activities that the organisations employed. Studies show that the SWPOs, at least in some states in the US and in Italy, were more active in advocating for the profession (for example, by campaigning for social work registration, recognition or remuneration) and were much less ready to promote policies regarding social issues (Guidi, 2020). However, research shows that SWPOs in different countries (the US, Australia and Spain) also acted as collective actors to advance the well-being, welfare and rights of service users, and to oppose planned policies that would negatively affect them (Mendes et al, 2015). SWPOs sought to impact policies related to social security, poverty, migration, mental health, child welfare, health, foster care and child welfare, or those dealing with such public issues as abortion, wages and the death penalty (Scanlon et al, 2006; Guidi, 2020). The engagement of SWPOs in these areas was frequently the subject of internal debates and conflicts (Mendes, 2003).

SWPOs in different countries act as collective policy actors by proxy or through recruitment networks. In policy involvement by proxy, the organisations engage in policy on behalf of their members, for example: when they declare that they support a specific policy proposal in the media (Guidi, 2020); when their staff engage in lobbying efforts, such as meeting with members of parliament or giving testimony in parliamentary committees; when they join coalitions; when they develop a policy position and send it to policymakers (Scanlon et al, 2006; Mendes et al, 2015); or when they endorse candidates for public office and provide funds for endorsed candidates (Colby and Buffum, 1998). When they function as recruitment networks, SWPOs

recruit SWs for diverse political actions and encourage them to participate directly in policy processes, for example: to testify on specific pieces of legislation (Beimers, 2015); to write letters to a minister or to contact parliamentary candidates (Mendes, 2003); to work on political campaigns (Scanlon et al, 2006); to appear on radio and television (Mendes, 2003); to join a petition; to participate in a demonstration (Mendes et al, 2015); to run for political office (Scanlon et al, 2006); or to endorse a political party. Efforts have also been made to educate SWs about electoral issues (Colby and Buffum, 1998).

Some of the research indicates that SWPOs tend to be wary of identifying with progressive groups or trade unions committed to a broader transformation of society (Mendes, 2003), or to shy away from direct conflictual activities that formally confront the government in public. Thus, while the Italian SWPO has employed a more restrictive neo-corporative strategy over the years, the Spanish SWPO adopted a citizen's movement strategy in reaction to austerity policies, which included large protests and involved other professional groups and service users (Guidi, 2020).

Finally, social work scholars take part in diverse policy activities. A quantitative cross-national study (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2017) found that academics were most likely to participate in public, rather than more traditional academic forms of policy-related activities. Thus, they sought to influence policy through protest activity, giving press interviews, serving on policy-related committees and engaging in activities aimed at impacting policy in conjunction with social work partners (students, service users and practitioners) more than sending publications to decision makers, formulating policy papers and serving as policy advisors. Similar findings emerged in studies undertaken in Canada (Shewell et al, 2021) and Ethiopia (Baynesagn, 2020).

Explanations

In recent years, there are signs of more theoretically driven and systematic empirical efforts to identify the factors that explain SWs' policy engagement in the different policy routes (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2015; Guidi, 2020; Kindler and Ostrander, 2022). The policy engagement conceptual framework (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2023) provides a useful way to describe this volume of research and to present the factors that the research identified. The framework links four categories of factors: environments, opportunity, facilitation and motivation.

'Environments' describes the political, social, economic and professional context in which SWs' policy engagement occurs. Historical case studies (Branco, 2020) on the role of SWs in establishing the Children's Bureau in the US in 1912 are a good example. These showed how a key environmental component, that is, the perceived severity of social problems, and Progressive Era concerns about the impact of poverty on infant mortality, the prevalence of child labour and the welfare of mothers and their children contributed to SWs' motivation to engage in policy and to the readiness of decision makers to accede to the demands to establish the Children's Bureau. The way in which policy changes, another facet of the environment, can impact SWs' VPP is demonstrated in a study by Mark Ezell (1993). Here, Ezell showed how the social policies of the Reagan administration in the US led to a marked rise in political activism among SWs.

The social work profession is another component of the environment that impacts SWs' policy engagement. The degree to which the social work professional

socialisation process highlights the social justice goals of the profession and encourages social worker students and professionals to undertake policy-related activities has been linked to SWs' motivation to engage in PP and VPP and to run for office (Rocha, 2000; Lane et al, 2018; Witt et al, 2020). The impact of the profession on the recruitment of SWs to the policy-related activities of SWPOs can also be observed. This emerges in the conclusions of Riccardo Guidi's (2020) study on the differing levels of policy engagement of SWs in Spain and Italy during the Great Recession. He links this to the degree of embeddedness of professional organisations in the political system and a readiness by SWPOs to move beyond a narrow focus on achieving professional goals to more social justice concerns.

Service users are another key element in the environment. In two Israeli studies on the PP of community SWs, it emerged that pressure from service users and members of the community encouraged SWs to engage in PP (Aviv et al, 2021; Gilboa and Weiss-Gal, 2022). This influence can also take a more structured form, as is the case of service users living in poverty that participated in the formulation of policies alongside SWs in Flanders (Boone et al, 2019). The origin of this approach was the formulation of the general report on poverty in Belgium between 1992 and 1995. A study of this process shows how it brought together people living in poverty with SWs and other professionals in the formulation of policies to address poverty (Degerickx et al, 2020).

The second and least-studied category of factors that influence the extent and forms of SWs' policy engagement is 'opportunity'. This category assumes that SWs' policy involvement, in the various policy routes, is dependent on both institutional and temporal factors, which determine access to the policy formulation process (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2020). Institutional factors refer to the norms, rules and modes of operation of the policy process, and the degree to which these create opportunities or obstacles to the access of SWs to this process. Thus, in the US political system, lobbying or legislative advocacy is a key strategy to further policy goals. Indeed, research shows that the NASW and its state chapters, as well as SWs engaging in PP on behalf of the civil society organisations that employ them, primarily used lobbying tactics in order to further policy change (Beimers, 2015). In Israel, by contrast, parliamentary committees are a key element in the policy formulation process, and the participation of experts and other interested parties in the deliberations of parliamentary committees is encouraged. Quantitative and qualitative research on participation by SWs in these committees indicates that this institutional feature of the Israeli system offers SWs access to the policy process. During a seven-year period (1999–2006), SWs participated in 14 per cent of the deliberations of parliamentary committees. Most of the SWs were civil servants (58 per cent) or professionals employed by local authorities (28 per cent) (Weiss-Gal and Gal, 2014).

Studies on the PP of SWs in local authorities provide an additional insight on the impact of institutional opportunities on SWs' policy engagement on the local level (Zhang et al, 2021). This emerges in an Israeli study on three case studies of policy efforts by SW policy entrepreneurs. Conditions that facilitated successful policy outcomes were created by: relatively lax and informal rules determining access to decision makers and to decision-making forums for employees within local authorities; the less-than-rigid hierarchical structure of urban government; the capacity of committee chairs within city councils to invite relevant parties to their deliberations; and the readiness of elected and non-elected officials to meet with SWs employed by local authorities (Aviv et al, 2021).

Temporal opportunity factors relate to developments in the political arena that offer SWs access to the policy process. These ‘policy windows’ (Kingdon, 2003) can include changes in the political map following elections or within legislative bodies that bring to power political forces with which SWs are aligned or politicians who are attuned to their policy agenda. The ascent of SWs to key positions in the Roosevelt administration in the US during the 1930s reflects this. Historical research shows that many of these SWs, in particular, the two most prominent among them – Frances Perkins (who served as secretary of labour) and Harry Hopkins (who led major New Deal agencies) – had previously worked with Roosevelt in New York and were actively involved in his election campaign (Hopkins, 1999; Burnier, 2008). This enabled them to play major roles in policy formulation during that period and led to additional SWs taking up posts in the administration.

‘Facilitation’ relates to the degree to which the organisational context in which SWs operate enables them to engage in policy-related activities. Most SWs are employees of organisations, so their decisions as to whether and through what route to engage in a policy-related activity will be influenced by this. Their engagement in policy will be impacted by the rules, dominant values and modes of practice in their immediate work environment. This ‘organisational culture’ affects the policies they choose to impact and the policy strategies they decide to employ (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2023). Research indicates that organisational support is useful in explaining SWs’ adoption of VPP (Makarov and Moshe Grodofsky, 2016), academic policy engagement (Gal and Weiss-Gal, 2017) and PP (Weiss-Gal, 2017b; Nouman et al, 2019; Weiss-Gal and Gal, 2020; Nouman and Azaiza, 2021).

The conclusion that emerges from this body of research is that organisational culture is a key factor in explaining SWs’ policy engagement, though the form it takes and the ways it relates to the policy engagement of SWs diverges much across organisations. Thus, for example, in a study on the policy advocacy of SWs and other health professionals in hospitals in the US, tangible support by management for policy advocacy was a major explanatory variable (Jansson et al, 2016).

The final category of variables – ‘motivation’ – received the greatest research attention. ‘Motivation’ encompasses individual-level factors that influence the willingness of SWs to engage in policy-related activities. The research identified a range of individual-based factors, which include the SWs’ perceptions, attitudes, knowledge, values, skills, traits, identities (for example, gender and ethnicity) and job-related characteristics. For example, in a qualitative study on eight Canadian SWs elected in 2015 as representatives of the New Democratic Party to the provincial Legislative Assembly of Alberta, the findings showed that the SWs attributed their political career to their commitment to social justice and public citizenship, as well as involvement in the public sphere, which were created by early political socialisation. They linked their transition to politicians to the values and knowledge acquired in their social work education, especially macro or systemic perspectives on social problems. They also reported that social work education provided them with the relevant and necessary skills for their work as politicians (McLaughlin et al, 2019).

The civic voluntarism model (Verba et al, 1995) offered a much-used theoretical basis for identifying motivational factors (Weiss-Gal, 2017b; Hoefer, 2021). In particular, scholars have underscored the impact of civic or political skills, a psychological engagement with politics (self-efficacy to engage in politics or political interest) and membership in recruitment networks on policy engagement. This was the case for

VPP (Ritter, 2008; Kindler and Ostrander, 2022), running for elected office (Lane and Humphreys, 2011; Greco, 2020; Amann and Kindler, 2022; Binder and Weiss-Gal, 2022), PP (Weiss-Gal and Gal, 2020) and a readiness of SWs to participate in the policy activities of SWPOs (Hoefler et al, 2019).

Personal values, often reflecting family background and life experiences, and professional attitudes forged in the professional socialisation process have been identified as a motivational component of SWs' policy engagement in various policy routes (Weiss-Gal, 2017b; Greco, 2020). These can be broad values, particularly a commitment to social justice (Mendes, 2007), or a more concrete conviction that policy engagement is an integral part of the role of social work (Lavee and Cohen, 2019; Nouman et al, 2019; Binder and Weiss-Gal, 2022; Gilboa and Weiss-Gal, 2022). Research also identifies the formal role that SWs hold within an organisation as a source of motivation. This is particularly the case for SWs in managerial positions. The finding that SWs holding administrative positions engage more in policy activities as citizens or professionals than front-line SWs emerged in an early study by Irwin Epstein (1981). Later studies found that SW managers engage more in policy because they have more opportunities, greater expectations and more knowledge and self-efficacy (Makarovs et al, 2020). Finally, studies have identified personality traits (Schwartz-Tayri, 2020), gender (Meehan, 2019; Ostrander et al, 2019; Shin, 2020) and ethnicity (Bent-Goodley, 2003; Lane and Humphreys, 2011; Nouman and Azaiza, 2021; Darawshy et al, 2022) as factors that influence SWs' engagement in policy routes.

Conclusion and a research agenda

Although social work is often perceived as a political profession formally committed to impacting the social and structural environment, it has been described as 'the dog that didn't bark' (Jordan and Jordan, 2000), while SWs have been depicted as 'unfaithful angels' (Specht and Courtney, 1995). We beg to disagree. Evidence that SWs adopted Clement Attlee's suggestion that they should engage in 'agitation' is strong. Research on the policy engagement of SWs across the world shows that SWs follow different policy routes as citizens and professionals in order to influence the policies of the organisations in which they are employed and those of local and national governments. This is not what most SWs do most of their time, and the claim that they do not engage in policy change enough certainly has merit. Nevertheless, the research discussed here shows that SWs and their representative organisations employ a variety of activities to influence policies.

Although the policy routes and the range of forms of policy engagement that SWs adopt is very diverse, studies indicate that, in most cases, SWs and their professional organisations distance themselves, from 'unconventional' or 'non-institutionalised' political activities in the policy realm. SWs generally opt for policy activities that are more consensual, frequently informal and low-key, and mostly directed at their immediate environment, such as local policies.

The research literature sheds light on the factors that determine SWs' policy engagement in the different routes. The environments within which they practice, as well as their temporal or institutional opportunities to access the policy process, create the different contexts in which they play a policy role, and this influences the level and forms of their engagement. This clearly emerges in cross-national studies of policy engagement. In addition, especially when SWs engage in policy as professionals,

the readiness of the organisations of which they are a part to enable them to become policy actors is critical for understanding their level and forms of policy engagement. Yet, research shows that within these environmental, institutional and organisational contexts, SWs have agency. Motivated SWs who witness the difficulties faced by their service users and have the skills, the political efficacy and the conviction that policy engagement is part of their duty will engage more in policy-change activities.

While this overview seeks to present a full description of existing knowledge on the policy engagement of social workers, it has obvious limitations. Not being based on a systematic literature review, there may be research that has been overlooked or missed. Moreover, this article is based primarily on English-language publications and does not reflect the scholarly discourse in most other languages. Although a number of the publications reported here pertain to SWs' policy engagement in the Global South, most of the existing English-language research tends to relate to trends in the Global North, and this is reflected in the findings presented here. This inevitably fails to capture the possible richness of SWs' policy engagement in countries beyond this limited geographic region.

Despite the growth in research on the policy engagement of SWs in recent decades and the insights that this has offered, our understanding of this key social work role remains only partial and much remains to be documented and explained. Clearly, there is a need to widen the scope of studies to include additional regions in the world, particularly those in the Global South. The work of scholars seeking to better understand the policy engagement of SWs could be enhanced if research methodologies rarely employed in this field, including qualitative narrative approaches, participatory research, historical methods and case studies using policy tracing, are adopted. These would offer additional perspectives to this body of knowledge. Our knowledge will also be enriched if future quantitative research draws upon larger surveys of policy engagement in the different routes by employing random and representative samples of SWs around the world. Measurements should clearly distinguish between policy activities in each of the routes, particularly with regard to policy activities in the work setting and those undertaken as part of SWs' VPP. Further research is also needed on the extent, forms and factors of the policy engagement of SWPOs. The knowledge on this route is very limited. Similarly, knowledge on SWs holding elected offices around the world will offer a better understanding of this relatively unexplored route. Moreover, we can only assume that there are additional policy routes that exist, which further studies in different contexts and settings will identify.

In order to expand knowledge on the factors that contribute to SWs' policy engagement, there is undoubtedly a need to identify additional variables in each of the explanatory categories described here. Culture and religion are virtually unexplored but potentially important environments that may have an impact of policy engagement. The same is the case for the impact of welfare-state structuring and of the degree of openness of political systems. There are conceivably personality traits and values not yet studied that can be essential sources of motivation. The interaction between the various categories and their components also remains a challenge. We still do not understand fully how professional socialisation affects the perceptions of policy involvement, the values and the political efficacy of social work students and SWs to engage in different routes, and what the exact dynamics are of the choices that SWs make when deciding which policy route to choose. Similarly, there is limited research

on the role of service users in motivating SWs and professional organisations to engage in policy, their impact on the internal dynamics of social welfare organisations, and the opportunities that SWs have to impact policy. Finally, we have very little knowledge concerning the outcome of SWs' policy engagement. We know very little about what explains their success not only in being part of the game, but also in creating policy change. Case studies and historical research will facilitate this and undoubtedly encourage the profession to be much more engaged in policy change.

Note

¹ An additional route through which SWs can, and do, impact policy is street-level policy engagement, which refers to SWs' involvement in implementing policies through their actions and decisions as front-line practitioners. As this is not an intentional effort to affect policy design, we will not relate to this route in the article.

Conflict of interest

The authors declare that there is no conflict of interest.

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